

SWAB STORY
People line up for COVID-19 tests in Shanghai, May 31

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cases and 213 deaths reported in the first two years of the pandemic. A preprint paper on MedrXIV published in March 2022 found that those without vaccination and prior exposure faced as much risk of fatality with this variant as that in the past. Perhaps it is not the virus then that is milder but human immunity that is getting stronger.

It may not always be enough, though. Already BA.2.12.1, which comes with heightened immune escape mutations compared to BA.2, has caused a wave in the US where daily cases are exceeding 100,000 again. Experts had predicted that antibodies from BA.2 might deter the new sub-variant but it doesn't seem so.

India's last major outbreak was led by BA.2. According to the latest data, the BA.2 sub-lineage remains dominant, accounting for 63.5 per cent of all genetic sequences until early May 2022, followed by BA.2.10 (14 per cent) and BA.2.38 (8-9 per cent). The last variant found so far in Uttar Pradesh, Delhi, Gujarat, Telangana, Haryana and Rajasthan comes with a K417T mutation, which is known to make it even easier for the virus to spread.



WE DON'T HAVE THE SURGES FOUND IN OTHER COUNTRIES, BUT IT'S A REMINDER THAT THE VIRUS IS STILL AROUND. **IT CAN MUTATE ELESEWHERE, OR IN INDIA.** WE CAN'T DISCARD BEING CAREFUL

DR PRIYA ABRAHAM
Director, NIV, Pune

TESTING TROUBLE

Another problem is that we may not know the true spread of Covid in India due to a number of people opting for home tests. Unlike RT-PCR, it is purely up to individuals to declare the results of a home test. There is also a higher chance of false negatives if home tests are taken incorrectly. One can't be sure, therefore, whether the spike in cases earlier this month in some states was just a couple of thousands as reported or in tens of thousands. In January, 200,000 people took antigen tests at home and reported them to ICMR (the Indian Council of Medical Research), compared to just 3,000 in all of 2021. The number of RT-PCR tests is on the decline, with only 278,267 tests on May 29, compared to 1.4 million on January 23. "Home tests have reduced the demand for RT-PCRs. Many countries also don't insist on a negative report but ask for a vaccine certificate instead," says Dr Harsh Mahajan, founder and chief radiologist at Mahajan Imaging in Delhi.

What this means is that India may be missing its true positivity rate. In Maharashtra, chemists kept records of purchasers of home test kits, but other states have not been as pro-active. "The number of people testing positive is important data to ascertain spread and new variants in the country," says Srinath Reddy, chairman of the Public Health Foundation of India in Delhi.

Experts feel that vaccines alone will help reduce the impact of a new variant. "We need to develop vaccines with more long-term immunity," says Dr Reddy. Till such time, boosters are critical. You never know when the new variant will strike. If it hasn't already. ■